Module 13: AI Tools Landscape and Your Starter Stack

Which AI tool to use for which job, what each one costs, what you need before you start, and how the AI Tools Lab classes fit together.

Product Management Master Handbook
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Built from the 55-lecture course study guide and extended to the 12-module Product Core curriculum.
Hypothetical examples are labelled; no real company results are invented.

Contents

13.1 How to use the AI Tools Lab 3
13.2 The AI tools map 4
13.3 Which tool for which job 6
13.4 What it costs: free versus paid 7
13.5 What you need before you start 9
13.6 Accounts, API keys and safety 9
13.7 A starter stack for three budgets 11
13.8 How the classes connect: one example project 11
13.9 Exercises with model answers 12
13.10 Key takeaways 12
13.11 Check your understanding 13
13.12 Recommended resources 13

MODULE 13

AI Tools Landscape and Your Starter Stack

Which AI tool to use for which job, what each one costs, what you need before you start, and how the AI Tools Lab classes fit together.

≈ 4 h study

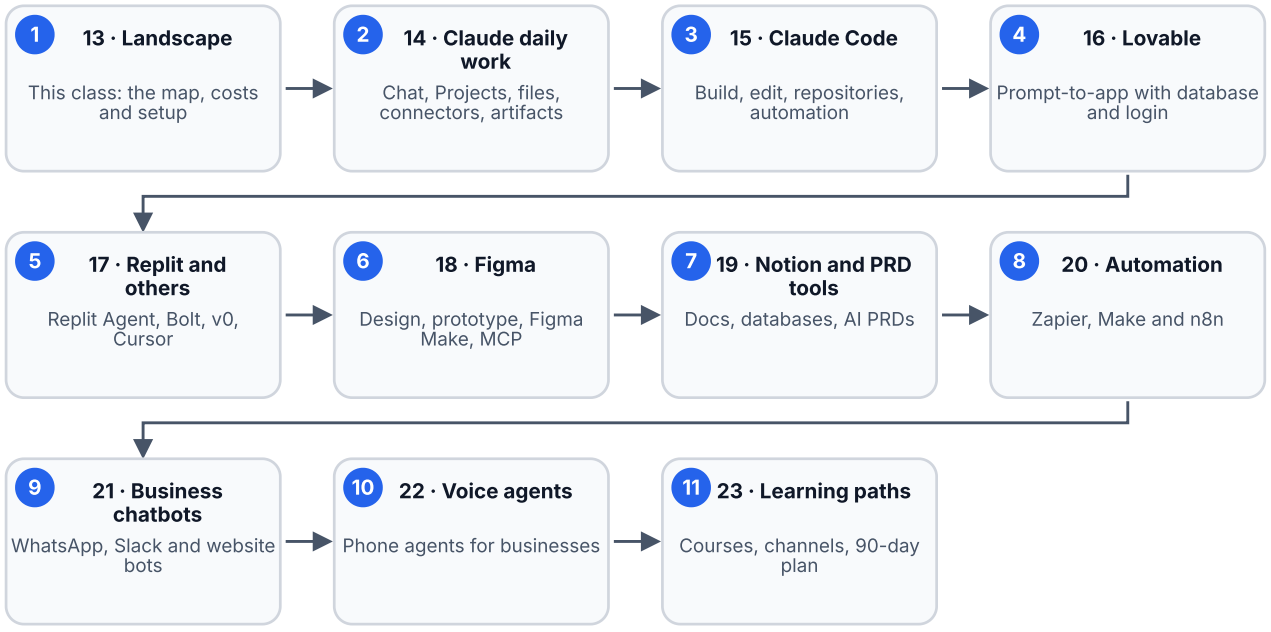
Prices and features change every month

Every price, free limit and feature name in the AI Tools Lab was checked on **23 October 2026** against official pages or, where noted, several independent reviews. AI tools change quickly, so **check the official pricing page before you pay or teach from these numbers**. Screens in this lab are **illustrative wireframes** that show the layout and the order of clicks. They are not real screenshots, and button names may differ slightly in the live product.

13.1 How to use the AI Tools Lab

The AI Tools Lab is a set of hands-on classes. Each class follows the same pattern, so you can practise straight from the PDF:

1. **What the tool is and when to use it**, in plain words.
2. **What you need**: account, plan, cost, other tools.
3. **Level 1 (basic)**: your first result in under an hour.
4. **Level 2 (intermediate)**: the features working PMs use every week.
5. **Level 3 (advanced)**: connecting the tool to other apps, automating, and shipping.
6. **Labs**: numbered steps with a picture of each screen or workflow.
7. **Mistakes, exercises with model answers, a quiz and resources.**



The AI Tools Lab classes in suggested order. Classes 14 and 15 are the foundation. After them you can take 16 to 22 in any order, depending on what you need to build.

13.2 The AI tools map

AI tools for PMs fall into eight groups. Most real projects combine two or three groups, for example **Claude** to write the spec, **Lovable** to build the app and **n8n** to connect it to Gmail and Slack.

1 · AI ASSISTANTS

- Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Microsoft Copilot
- Think, write, analyse files, research
- Class 14

2 · CODING AGENTS

- Claude Code, Cursor, GitHub Copilot, Codex
- Edit real code and repositories
- Class 15

3 · APP BUILDERS

- Lovable, Replit, Bolt, v0, Figma Make
- Prompt to working web app
- Classes 16 and 17

4 · DESIGN

- Figma, FigJam, Figma Make
- Screens, prototypes, design systems
- Class 18

5 · DOCS, PRDS AND PLANNING

- Notion, ChatPRD, Confluence, Linear, Jira
- Specs, wikis, roadmaps
- Class 19

6 · AUTOMATION

- Zapier, Make, n8n
- Connect Gmail, Slack, Sheets, CRMs
- Class 20

7 · CHATBOTS

- WhatsApp Business Platform, Botpress, Voiceflow, n8n
- Answer customers in chat
- Class 21

8 · VOICE AGENTS

- Vapi, Retell AI, ElevenLabs Agents, Twilio
- Answer and make phone calls
- Class 22

The eight groups of AI tools a PM uses. Pick the group by the job. Pick the tool inside the group by cost, the integrations you need and what your team already uses.

13.3 Which tool for which job

If you want to...	Start with	Free to try?	Upgrade when
Write a PRD, summarise interviews, analyse a CSV	Claude (Projects + file upload)	Yes	You hit message limits or need Claude Code
Change code in a real repository	Claude Code	Needs Pro or API	Daily use: Max or a team plan
Build a clickable app with login and a database	Lovable	Yes (5 credits a day)	You need private projects or a custom domain
Build and host a full-stack app in the browser	Replit Agent	Yes (limited)	You publish more than one app
Design screens and a click-through prototype	Figma	Yes (Starter)	You need Dev Mode or more files
Keep specs, roadmaps and research in one place	Notion	Yes	You need full Notion AI (Business plan)
Send a Slack alert when an email arrives	Zapier	Yes (100 tasks a month)	You need multi-step Zaps
Build complex automations cheaply	n8n (self-hosted)	Yes (free software)	You want managed cloud hosting
Answer customers on WhatsApp	A WhatsApp BSP + n8n or Botpress	Trial credits only	Real customer traffic (per-message fees)
Answer phone calls with AI	Vapi or Retell AI	Trial credits	Any real calls (per-minute fees)

Job-to-tool chooser. Free tiers are enough to learn every tool in this lab. Real customer traffic (messages and calls) always costs money.

13.4 What it costs: free versus paid

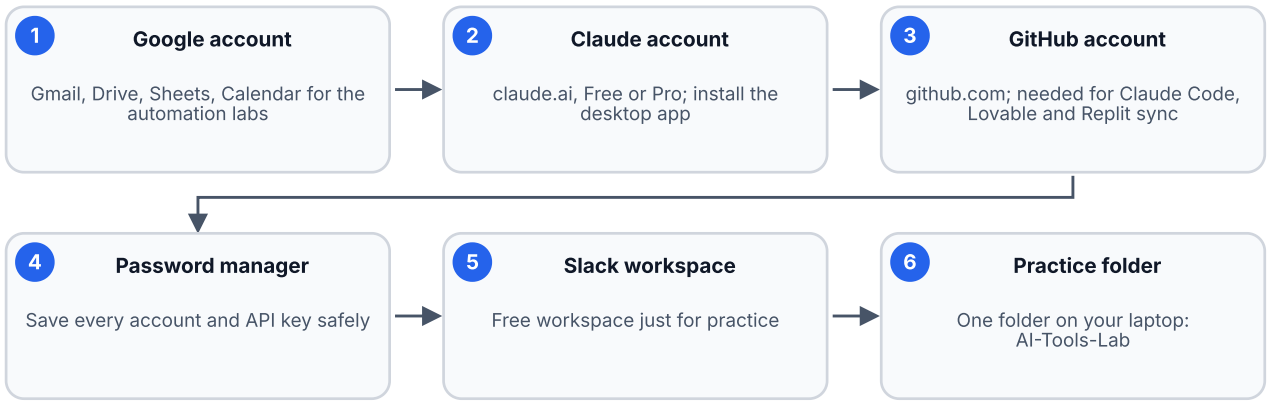
The rule for this lab

You can complete **every Level 1 lab for free**. Most Level 2 labs are free too. Paid tools appear only where real messages, phone calls, or production hosting are involved, and each class says so clearly.

Tool	Free tier	First paid tier	What you pay for
Claude	Free plan with limited messages	Pro, about $20 a month	More usage, Claude Code, more models; Max for heavy use
Claude API	No free tier for production	Pay per token	Building your own apps and bots on Claude
Lovable	5 credits a day (max 30 a month), public projects	Pro, about $25 a month (100 credits)	Private projects, custom domain, more credits
Replit	Starter: daily Agent credits, 1 published app	Core, about $20 to $25 a month	More Agent work, more apps, collaborators
Figma	Starter: limited files and AI credits	Professional, about $16 a month per full seat	Dev Mode, MCP server, more Figma Make use
Notion	Free plan, limited AI trial	Business, about $20 per member a month	Full Notion AI, agents, meeting notes
Zapier	100 tasks a month, two-step Zaps	Professional	Multi-step Zaps, more tasks
Make	1,000 credits a month, 2 active scenarios	Core	More credits and scenarios
n8n	Community Edition is free to self-host	Cloud Starter, about €20 to €24 a month	Managed hosting; you pay the server if self-hosting
WhatsApp Business Platform	No free tier for templates	Per delivered template message	Marketing, utility, authentication messages; check Meta's rate card
Voice agents (Vapi, Retell)	Trial credits	Usage, roughly $0.07 to $0.30 a minute all-in	Speech-to-text, AI model, voice, phone line

Free and paid tiers at a glance (checked 23 Oct 2026; verify before paying). Figures are rounded and come from the official pricing pages where available, otherwise from several 2026 reviews. Indian rupee prices vary by tax and billing region.

13.5 What you need before you start



One-time setup for the whole lab (about 45 minutes). Use a practice Gmail and a practice Slack workspace, so a mistake in a lab never emails a real customer or posts in a real company channel.

Hardware and software: any laptop from the last five years works. For Claude Code you also need a terminal (built into macOS and Windows) and, for some installs, **Node.js** from nodejs.org. Nothing in this lab needs a powerful computer, because the AI runs in the cloud.

13.6 Accounts, API keys and safety

Many labs connect one app to another. There are three ways apps connect, and you will meet all three:

Easiest	**Built-in connector or integration: click Connect, sign in, approve**
Middle	**API key or OAuth credential pasted into an automation tool**
Most control	**MCP server: lets an AI assistant use another app's tools**

Three ways tools connect to each other. Connectors are what you use most. API keys appear in n8n, chatbots and voice agents. MCP (Model Context Protocol) is how Claude and Claude Code use tools such as Figma, Notion, GitHub and your own n8n workflows.

Five safety rules for every lab

1. **Never paste an API key into a chat, a document, a prompt, or frontend code.** Keep keys in the tool's secret store (n8n credentials, Lovable or Replit secrets, Netlify environment variables).
2. **Use test data.** Do not upload customer data, salary data or anything under NDA to a free AI plan. Check your company's AI policy first.
3. **Approve actions one by one** until a workflow has run correctly at least ten times.
4. **Turn off what you no longer use.** Disconnect connectors and delete unused API keys.
5. **Set spending limits** on every paid API (Anthropic Console, OpenAI, Twilio, Vapi) before your first test.

13.7 A starter stack for three budgets

₹0 A MONTH (LEARNING)

- Claude Free
- Lovable Free
- Figma Starter
- Notion Free
- Zapier Free or n8n on your laptop
- Telegram bot for chat practice
- Voice agent trial credits

ABOUT $45 A MONTH (SERIOUS PM)

- Claude Pro (includes Claude Code)
- Lovable Pro
- Figma and Notion free tiers
- n8n self-hosted on a small server
- Pay-as-you-go API with a $10 limit

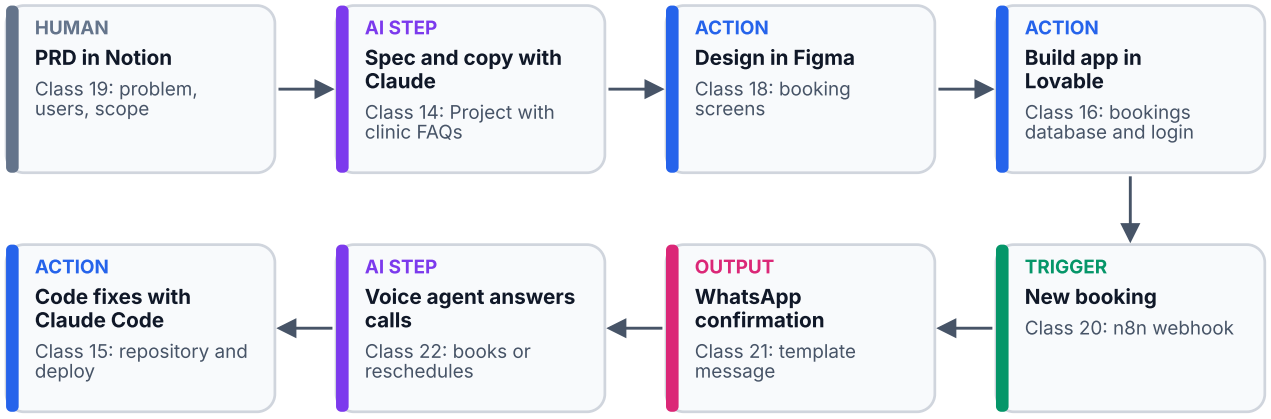
TEAM OR CLIENT WORK

- Claude Team or Max
- Lovable or Replit paid
- Figma Professional
- Notion Business
- n8n Cloud or Make Core
- WhatsApp BSP and a voice agent platform on usage billing

Starter stacks. Start at ₹0. Upgrade one tool at a time, only when a free limit is actually blocking you.

13.8 How the classes connect: one example project

The capstone that ties the lab together is a **small business assistant** for a hypothetical clinic. Each class adds one piece:



Capstone: a clinic's AI front desk, built across the lab. Hypothetical project for practice. Use test phone numbers and made-up patients only. Node types shown: Action · AI step · Human step · Output · Trigger (starts the flow).

13.9 Exercises with model answers

Exercise 1 · Pick the tools

A D2C brand wants: a landing page with a waitlist form, an email to each signup, and a weekly Slack summary of signups. Which tools would you use, free first?

Model answer

Landing page and form: **Lovable** (free tier) or **Claude artifacts** for a quick static page. Email and Slack: **Zapier** (free covers a two-step "new form row → send email" Zap) plus a second Zap for the weekly summary, or one **n8n** workflow that does both. Summary text: an **AI step** (Claude via n8n, or Zapier's AI step). Paid only when signups exceed the free task limits.

Exercise 2 · Spot the risk

A teammate pasted the company's OpenAI API key into a Lovable prompt so the app "can talk to AI". What is wrong, and what should they do?

Model answer

The key is now in the chat history and may end up in frontend code where any visitor can read it. **Revoke the key immediately**, create a new one, and store it as a **secret** (Lovable Cloud or Supabase secrets) used only by a server-side function. Set a spending limit on the new key.

13.10 Key takeaways

- Choose the tool group by the **job**, and the tool by **cost, integrations and team fit**.
- Every Level 1 lab is **free**. Messages, calls and production hosting are what cost money.
- Keep **secrets out of prompts and frontend code**, use **test data**, and set **spending limits**.
- Connectors, API keys and **MCP** are the three ways tools talk to each other.

13.11 Check your understanding

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Which group would you use to change code inside an existing GitHub repository?

A. AI assistants such as the Claude chat app

B. Coding agents such as Claude Code

C. Automation tools such as Zapier

D. Voice agents

Why: Coding agents read, edit and commit code in a real repository.

What usually costs money even when you are only testing a WhatsApp or phone bot with real people?

A. Writing the prompt

B. Designing the flow in Figma

C. Delivered messages and call minutes

D. Creating a Google account

Why: Messaging and telephony are billed per message or per minute.

Where should an API key for an automation live?

A. In the prompt so the AI can see it

B. In a shared Google Doc

C. In the tool's credential or secret store

D. In the website's JavaScript

Why: Credential stores keep keys encrypted and out of chats and frontend code.

13.12 Recommended resources

- Claude pricing · Lovable pricing · Replit pricing · Figma pricing
- Notion pricing · Zapier pricing · Make pricing · n8n pricing
- WhatsApp Business Platform pricing (Meta)
- Model Context Protocol — the standard behind Claude's connectors.